

IMPACT OF COVID-19 ON POST EARTHQUAKE RECOVERY AND RECONSTRUCTION

June 2020

In collaboration with:



नेपाल सरकार
राष्ट्रिय पुनर्निर्माण प्राधिकरण
सिंहदरबार, काठमाडौं

Report and Survey conducted by:



Housing Recovery and
Reconstruction Platform

Funded and Supported by:



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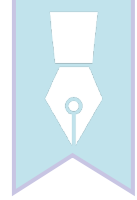
Housing Recovery and
Reconstruction Platform

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Executive Summary

Like everywhere else, the Corona Virus Disease (COVID-19) - now a global pandemic - has had severe impacts in almost all aspects of life in Nepal. The vulnerabilities in Nepal (especially in 32 earthquake affected districts) were even more because of the ongoing recovery and reconstruction following the Nepal Earthquake 2015. The measures taken to contain the spread of COVID-19 pandemic - lockdown with limited mobility - have crippled lives and caused far reaching consequences in all sectors of the economy. The fear is that these impacts might seriously undo some of the achievements seen over the past years or seriously impede the progress of earthquake recovery by the disruption of the support, labor and material markets and supply chain.

This assessment with various post-earthquake recovery stakeholders was carried out to understand the impact of the COVID-19 on recovery and reconstruction in the 32 earthquake affected districts. Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform employed telephonic survey as the COVID19-safe means of data collection. The assessment findings and recommendations are expected to contribute in formulating strategies for the National Reconstruction Authority to move ahead with the reconstruction during and after the COVID-19 lockdown.

Highlights

- Earthquake affected households: 58% reported to have completed, 26% still ongoing, 16% have not started. 35% of the people who have the reconstruction ongoing continue to do so despite the lockdown using locally available resources (masons and materials)
- Only 16% of technical staff were present in the field and carrying out inspection of houses where feasible leading to the disruption of about 83% of the field visits. These will have further implications on tranche disbursement and delivery of technical support.
- 45% of masons were working in duty stations where 95% out of them were involved in reconstruction of houses but with limited resources.
- The most sought information by the beneficiaries from municipalities and technical staff was on tranche update.
- A major challenge both in Rural and Urban was the availability of construction materials, where availability of masons and
- 50% POs reported their activities halted, others had some level of continuity and some had reduction in targets.
- In general, most respondents anticipated a 3 - 6 months delay in the reconstruction process.

Acronyms

COVID-19	Corona Virus Disease 2019
CLPIU	Central Level Project Implementation Unit
DLPIU	District Level Project Implementation Unit
GMaLI	Grant Management and Local Infrastructure
HRRP	Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform
M & E	Monitoring and Evaluation
MIS	Management Information System
NRA	National Reconstruction Authority
POs	Partner Organizations (Includes various I/NGOs supporting recovery and reconstruction in Nepal)
STA	Socio-Technical Assistance

Table of Contents

Introduction	1
Objectives	1
Methodology	2
Limitations	2
Demographic Profiling	3
CLPIU GMaLI and Building	4
Donor	5
Partner Organisations	5-6
Key Findings	
District Level Proj. Imp. Unit (DLPIU GMaLI and Building)	7
Technical Persons	10
Municipal Representatives	14
Beneficiaries	19
Social Mobilizers	24
Masons	27
Vendors and Producers	30
Other Challenges and Impact of COVID-19	32
Recommendations and the way forward	33

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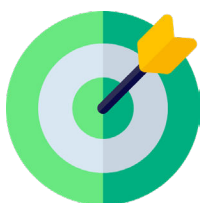
Introduction

As the global pandemic COVID-19 continues to bring more death and damage around the world, its impact in Nepal has also been very high. The health and economic impact of COVID-19 is more pronounced in Nepal still dealing with the effects of a large disaster and recovery and reconstruction efforts for the same.

Nepal experienced a devastating earthquake in 2015, and the recovery and reconstruction efforts are still ongoing. While everyone understood that post-earthquake reconstruction would be a long and challenging process, the coronavirus pandemic has brought a sudden and grinding halt to the progress made in repairing lives and reshaping homes and cities, affecting people's lives and livelihood in fundamental ways. The measures taken to contain the spread of COVID-19 pandemic - lockdown with limited mobility - have crippled lives and caused far reaching consequences in all sectors of the economy. The fear is that these impacts might seriously undo some of the achievements seen over the past years or seriously impede the progress in post-earthquake recovery by the disruption of the support, labor and material markets and supply chain. This is especially true when the return to normalcy is still not clearly outlined.

The current situation has also impacted the timeline set by the Government of Nepal to complete the earthquake recovery and reconstruction within five years of the establishment of National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), the focal coordination agency. December 2020 marks the five-year tenure of NRA and this will likely create another challenge in the recovery and reconstruction coordination.

Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform has been supporting the post-earthquake recovery and reconstruction stakeholders in Nepal including NRA, partner organizations, donors, private sector, and affected communities. This assessment on the impact of COVID19 on recovery and reconstruction is believed to capture the underlying concerns from various stakeholders and support the way forward.



Objectives

The following are the broad objectives that guided the assessment.

- To find the impact of COVID-19 crisis and lockdown on recovery and reconstruction as shared/experienced by reconstruction stakeholders.
- To compile and draw recommendations for NRA and decision makers for informed strategy to support the reconstruction process during and after lockdown period.



Methodology

The assessment employed quantitative and qualitative assessment methods with different reconstruction stakeholders to assess the situation of reconstruction during COVID-19 pandemic in 32 earthquake affected districts. The assessment included various reconstruction stakeholder groups ranging from national stakeholders to beneficiaries.

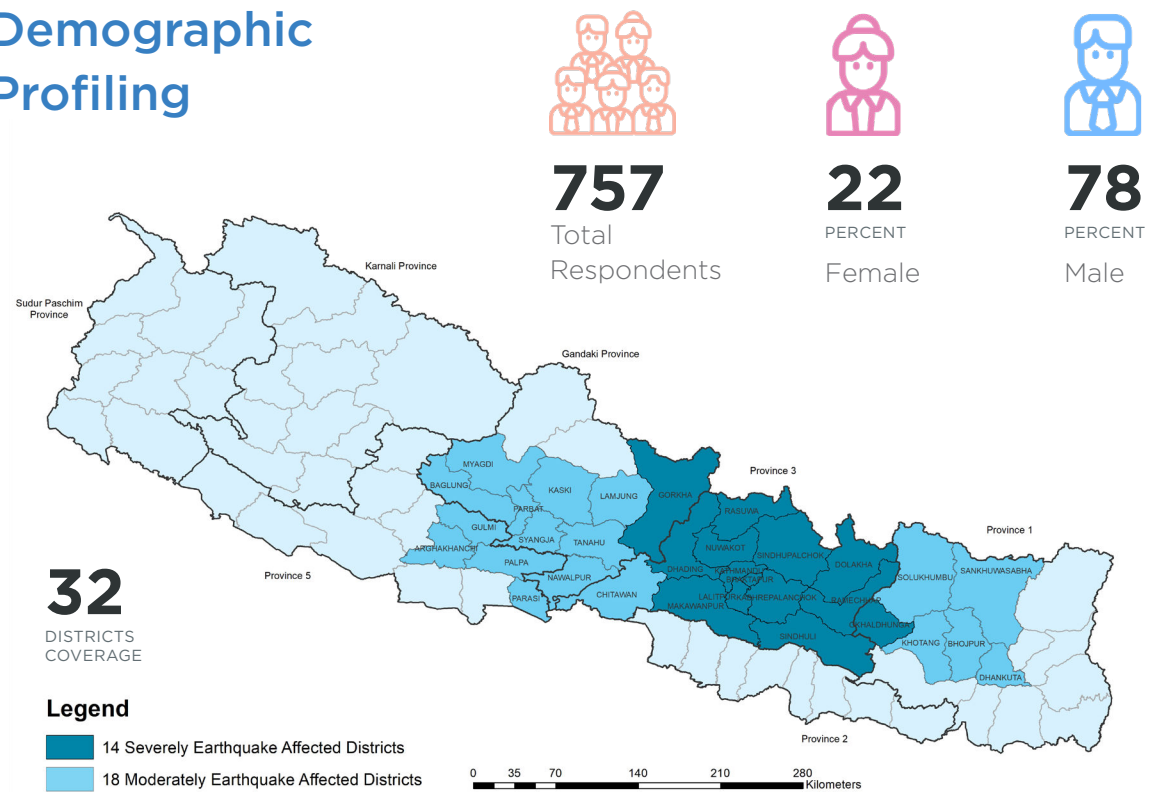
- Reconstruction and retrofitting Beneficiaries
- Municipal Representatives
- CLPIU Building
- CLPIU-GMaLI
- DLPIU-GMaLI
- DLPIU- Building
- Donor Agencies
- Partner Organizations (I/NGOS)
- Technical Persons (Engineers, Sub-Engineers, Social Mobilizers)
- Masons, Mobile Masons
- Material vendors and producers

The assessment was carried out on from 1-10 May 2020. The sample size for the beneficiaries, engineers and municipal representatives was estimated from the respective population at 90%-99% confidence level and a contingency factor of 10% for non-response. For social mobilizers and mobile masons recently recruited in the 14 moderately-affected districts, samples were drawn at 75% confidence level and 10% margin of error for social mobilizers and mobile masons. Data collection for the assessment was done through telephonic interviews encoded through Open Data Kit and Enketo by the HRRP district teams.

Limitations

Given the COVID-19 crisis, the survey was done by telephone interviews, this might have limited the understanding and interpretation of the questions in some cases. The representatives for various stakeholder groups at the national level were identified based on the existing relationships while at the sub-national level, the respondents were selected randomly. This had to be adjusted in a few cases due to unavailability.

Demographic Profiling



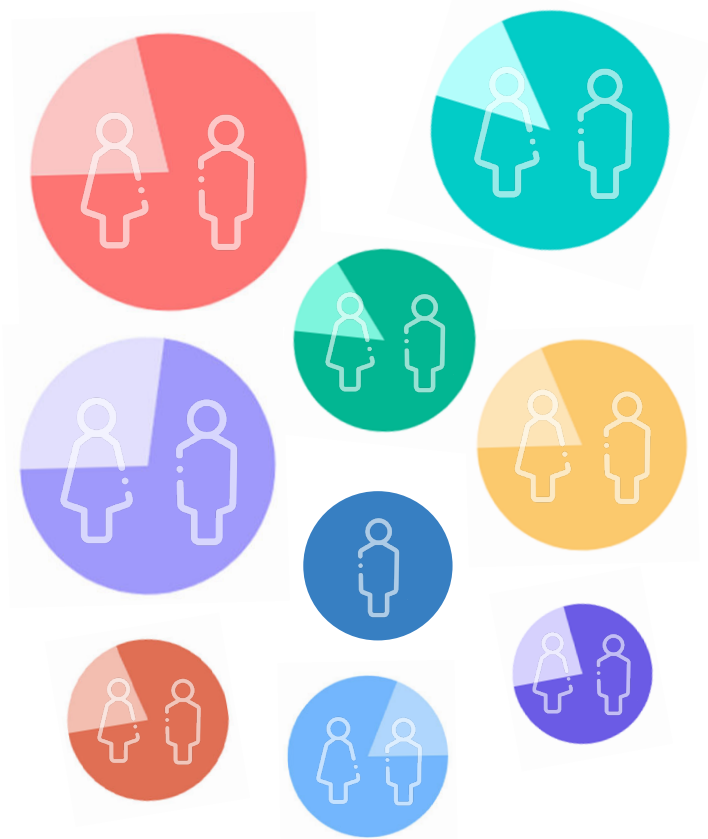
RESPONDENT TYPEs

- Reconstruction Beneficiaries
(Female: 75, Male: 272)
- Technical Persons
(Female: 17, Male: 108)
- Municipal Representatives
(Female: 19, Male: 50)
- DLPIU GMaLI
(Female: 7, Male: 41)
- Masons
(Female: 8, Male: 34)
- DLPIU Building
(Female: 8, Male: 30)
- Vendors and Producers
(Male: 33)
- Social Mobilizers
(Female: 26, Male: 6)
- Partner Organizations
(Female: 4, Male: 13)

OTHERS:
CLPIU GMaLI
(Male: 1)

CLPIU Building
(Male: 4)

Donor Agencies
(Female: 1)





CLPIU GMaLI and Building

- On average 58% technical staff are working from home whereas, 8.75% are at their duty stations.
- Continuing digitization of data and CS entry, providing guidance to technical staff in the field during the lockdown.
- COVID-19 has badly impacted on reconstruction resulting in a delay to complete the reconstruction on time.
- Challenges in the disbursement of tranche to the beneficiaries due to closure of banks and restriction in mobility.
- Distribution of tranche and analysis of the requirement of budget for further reconstruction work obstructed due to COVID-19.
- CLPIU still continued the distribution of tranche during this period of crisis with consultation and adjustment with the banking sectors.
- Proper allocation of budget according to needs of reconstruction and emphasis of proper planning on the area of maximum need.
- CLPIU GMaLI follows the guidelines of the GON for safety and security purposes of the staff and applies extra required measures for staff working at field level.



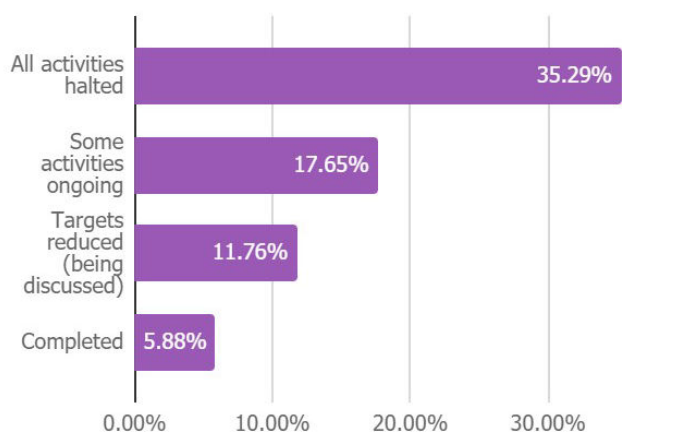
Donor

- Due to COVID-19 some programs are halted and are working remotely.
- Timeframe of the programs is possible to extend but the target would not be reduced
- Re-prioritizing programme/activities to ensure flex/adaptation to COVID-19 context which could include halting activities, but also re-designing certain elements.
- There will be no compromise in your funding commitment to the reconstruction sector because of the current crisis
- Suggested to explore socio-economic interventions, technical assistance, awareness campaigns, capacity development.
- Some donor agencies allowed the reconstruction programs funded to reallocate the 10% funds available for COVID-19 responses.



Partner Organizations

17 Partner Organizations responded to the survey. 35% of Partner Organization reported that their activities in the field have been halted due to COVID-19 pandemic lockdown. 18% had few activities ongoing and 12% were under discussion of reducing the targeted activities.

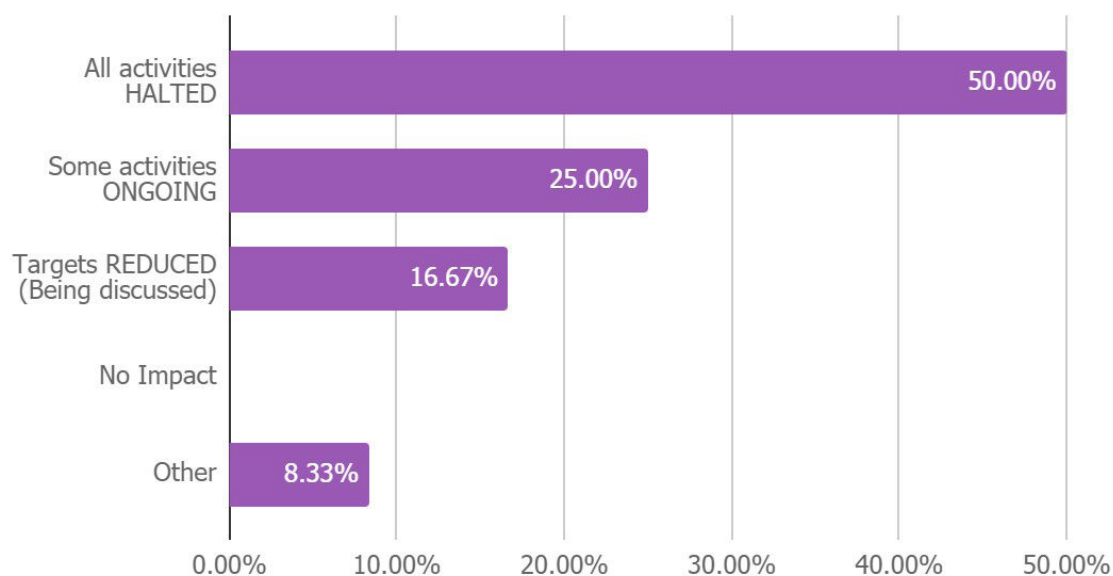




The major operational constraints in continuing the activities during the lockdown were

- Movement restriction due to the lockdown has halted transportation and also staff mobility.
- Considering safety and do-no harm, many activities entailing gathering like training, IECs have been halted.
- The unavailability of construction materials and the workforce for the construction.
- Government offices closure and uncertainty of the grants
- Impact on providing technical assistance and software activities.
- Uncertainties due to lockdown have limited commitment for new projects on technical assistance and supporting vulnerable families.
- Increased cost of carrying out activities.
- Challenges to secure passes for travel within and between the districts.
- Minimum movement of the staff affecting quality implementation and monitoring.

IMPACT of COVID-19 on Recovery and Reconstruction Activities

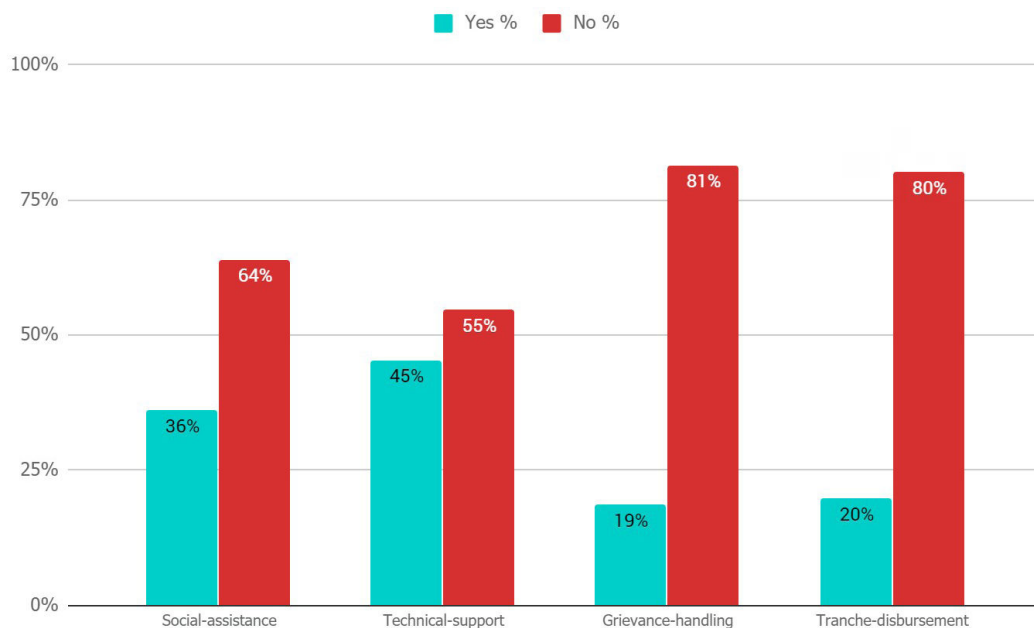




Key Findings

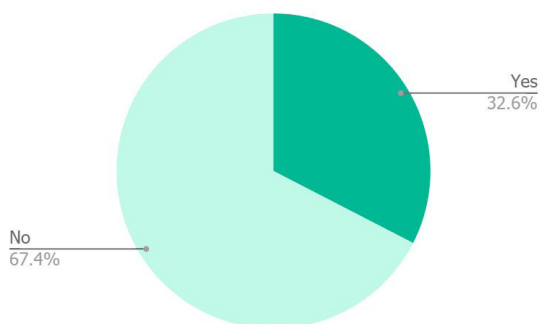
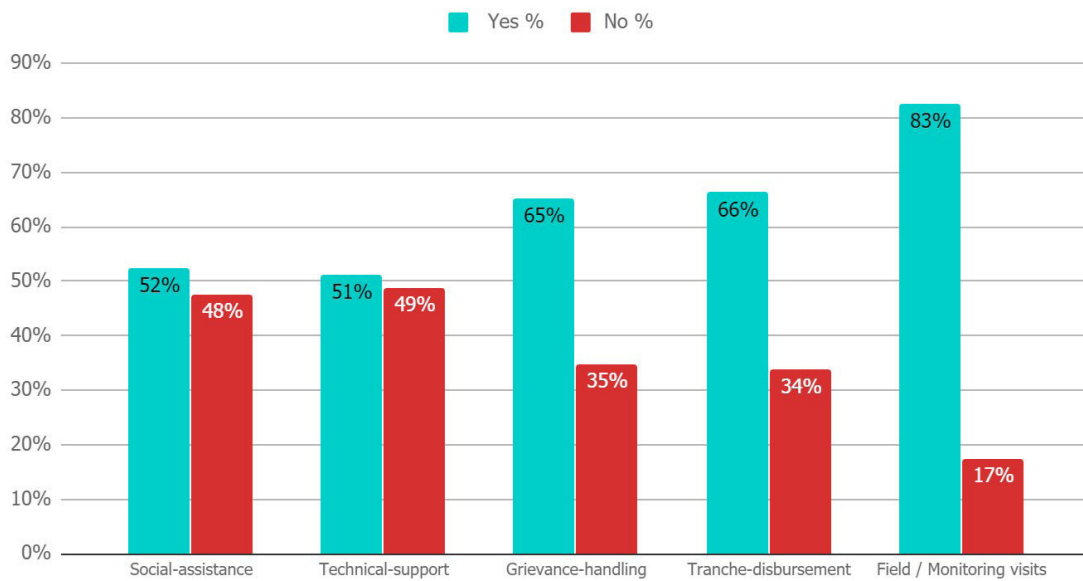
District Level Project Implementation Unit (DLPIU GMaLI and Building)

All the GMaLI and Building offices of each 32 earthquake affected districts were included in the survey and the respondents included Chiefs and Acting Chiefs of both GMaLI and Building, Focal persons, MIS Specialist, M&E Specialist, Environment Specialist, Financial Management Specialist, Administrative Officers, Computer Operators, Engineers and Sub-Engineers. GMaLI and Building offices were partially or fully opened with limited staff physically present at work while some staff were working from home. DLPIU GMaLI and Building noted that recovery and reconstruction related services were greatly hampered due to the COVID-19 lockdown. However, the major services such as providing social and technical assistance to the beneficiaries, tranche disbursement and grievance handling continued during the lockdown.





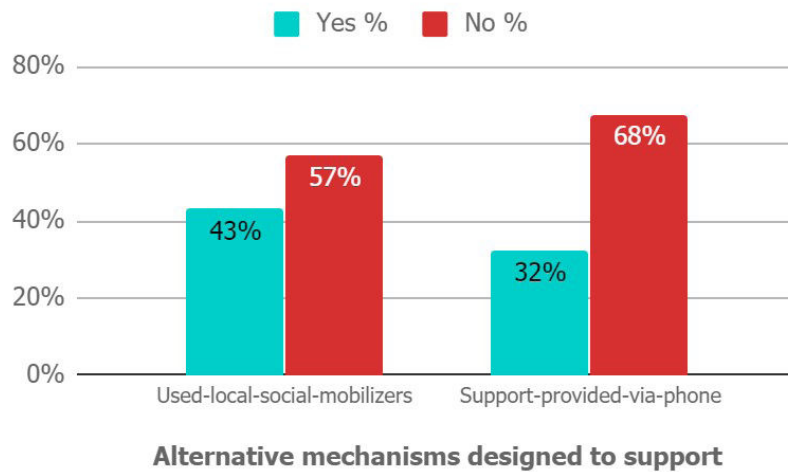
83% of the field visits have been completely halted due to travel restriction to contain the spread of the COVID-19 pandemic. Reduction in inspection and monitoring have implications on other services such as tranche disbursement, providing social technical assistance, grievance redressal and many other services that primarily depend on the inspection and monitoring of houses, impacting the overall reconstruction.



33% of DLPIU GMaLI and Building had alternative mechanisms in supporting beneficiaries doing reconstruction during lockdown. That included the mobilization of field technical staff and Social Mobilizers of the same area to support the beneficiaries as required. Responding to the queries and needs of beneficiaries via phone was commonly practiced.

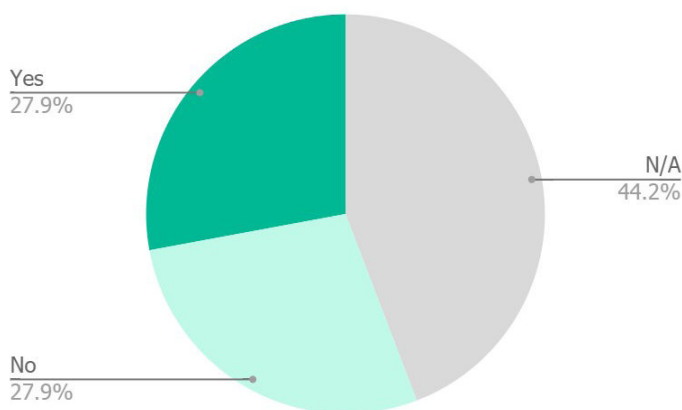
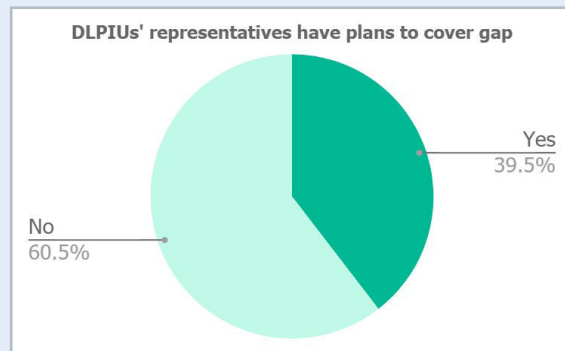


Responding to the queries and needs of beneficiaries via phone was commonly practiced.



40% of the DLPIU offices reported having plans to cover the gap in reconstruction caused by lockdown. Some of the plan shared were

1. To visit each municipality for coordination to prepare the action plan as per the need and gaps.
2. Conduct the refresher training to engineer and a day workshop, Increase the mobilization of the technicians and social mobilizers and masons at palika level.
3. Monitoring of Efficiency of work (Technical staffs) and Compliance issues by more field visits with extra working time.



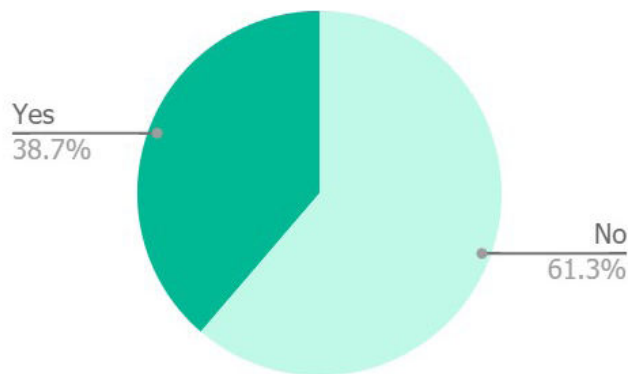
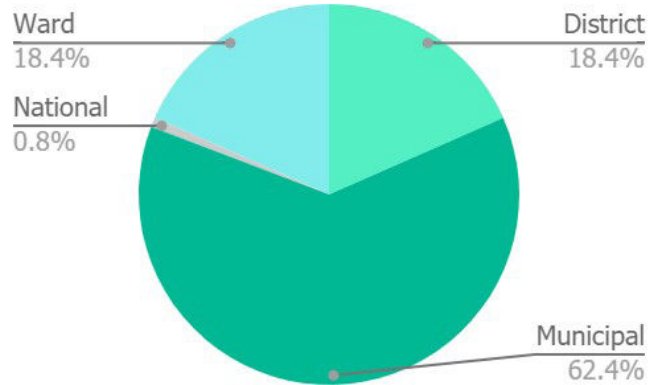
Only 30% of DLPIU representatives think the recovery and reconstruction can go ahead normally after the lockdown. 44% are not sure given the uncertainty of COVID-19 lockdown.



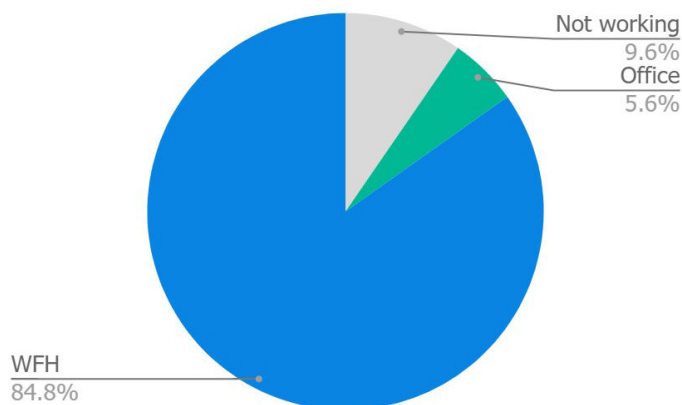
Key Findings

Technical Persons

A total of 125 Technical staff responded to the survey. The technical staff were Engineers, Sub Engineers, Assistant Engineers, Assistant Sub Engineers, Focal Engineers working at District, Municipal and Ward levels.



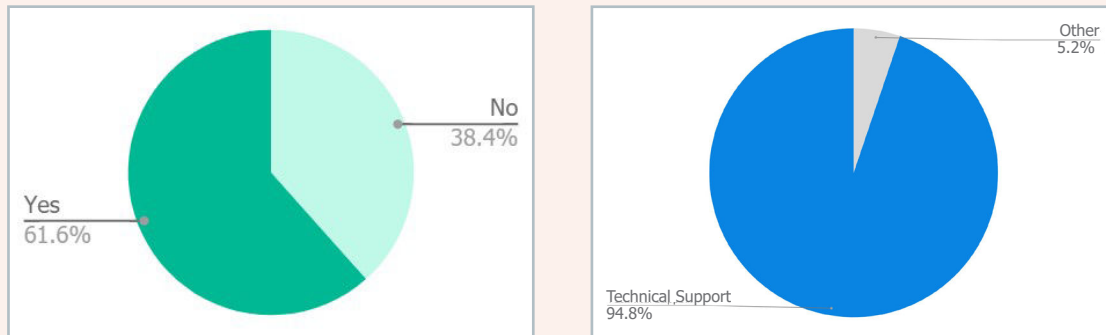
61% said they were not in their duty station while 39% were present in their working areas.



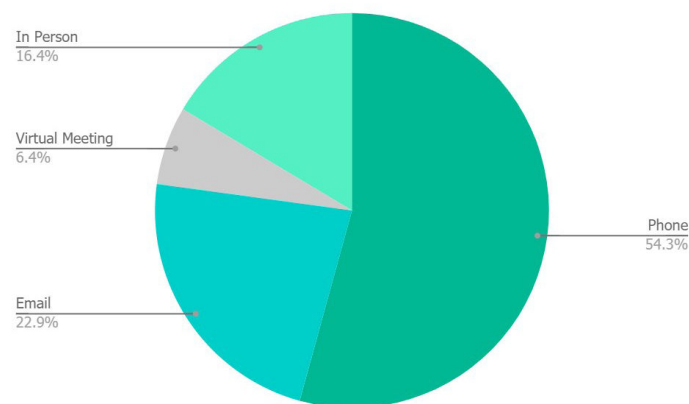
85% were working from home while 10% were not working at all.



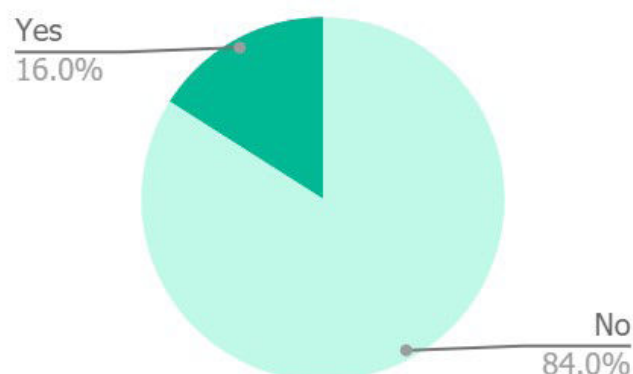
62% technical staff said they continued supporting recovery and reconstruction works in some way during the lockdown period. Out of them 95% were engaged in providing technical support and 5% in works such as CS entry, updating tranche data, supporting digitization and uploading of inspection data backlogs and documentation works.

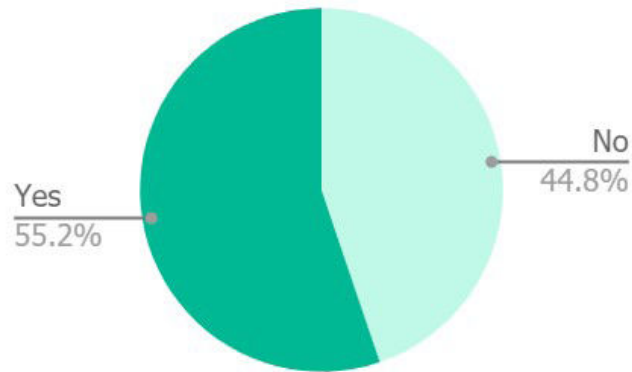


Majority of the technical staff who were continuing work, reported providing support to either CLPIU, DLPIU, municipal wards or beneficiaries via phone and only 16% were physically present in the field providing support to the beneficiaries.



Only 16% of the technical staff were carrying out inspection in the field compared to the pre-lockdown period due to movement restriction.





55% of technical staff reported that beneficiaries were reaching out to them for technical support and reconstruction related information.

Beneficiaries generally sought information on tranche updates (80%) as they were waiting to get their remaining tranches and about technical issues or concerns (78%) of their houses. They also asked for information on grievance updates and the new beneficiary list, if they were eligible for the government's financial grant. Some other queries were on the NRA tranche deadline, conversion from retrofitting to reconstruction and about house inspection.



80
PERCENT
Tranche
Update



78
PERCENT
Technical
Support



29
PERCENT
Grievance
Update



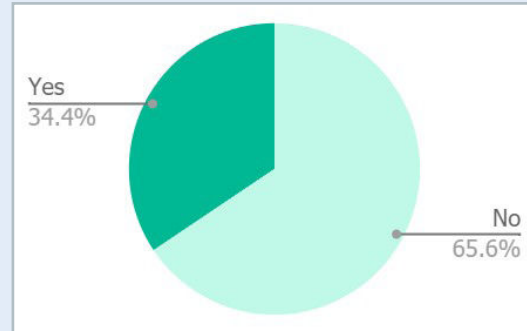
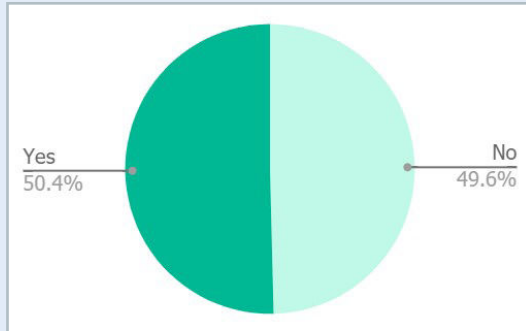
23
PERCENT
New Benef.
List



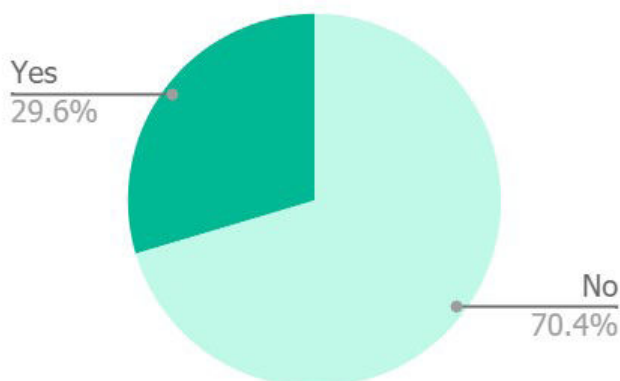
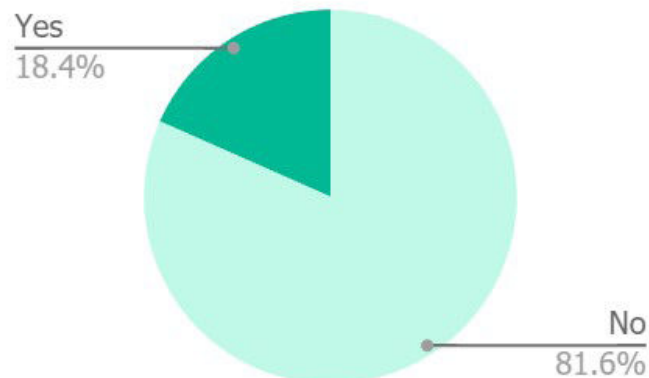
6
PERCENT
Others



While there were 50% of technical staff supporting the collection of information of the households that have not started reconstruction, there were only 34% who reported they were supporting the reconstruction of vulnerable households. This refers not only during lockdown. 66% reported they have not been supporting the reconstruction of vulnerable households at other times as well.



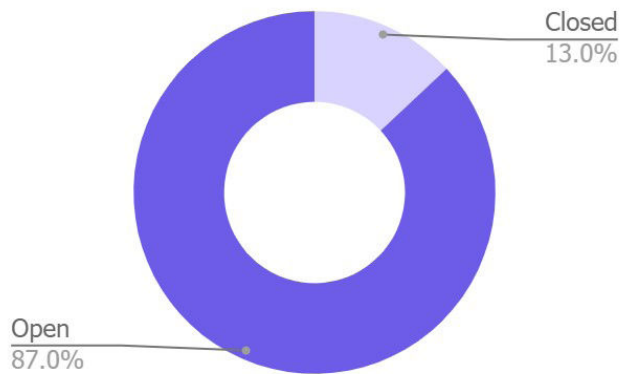
Only 18% reported having a monthly target of supporting reconstruction, retrofitting households including vulnerable households' reconstruction.



30% reported having an action plan to complete the reconstruction including that of vulnerable households.



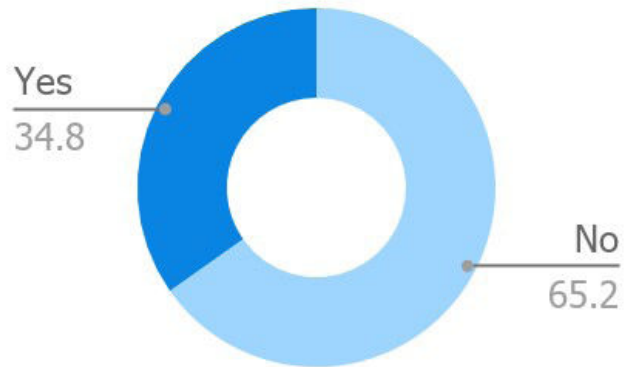
Key Findings



Municipal Representatives

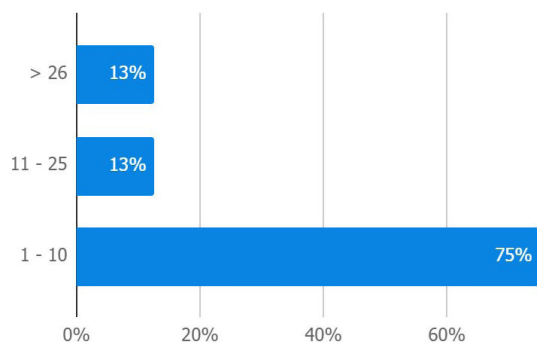
A total of 69 Municipal Representatives were interviewed including Mayor, Deputy Mayor, Deputy Mayor, Chairperson, Vice-Chairperson, Ward Chief and municipal council members. 87% of Municipal offices were open and 13% were not open during the COVID-19 lockdown.

35% of Municipalities noted that reconstruction works were going on in their areas amidst the COVID-19 lockdown. All of those households undergoing reconstruction had stock of construction materials that were procured before the nationwide lockdown was imposed and availability of local masons and labors to carry out the reconstruction works.



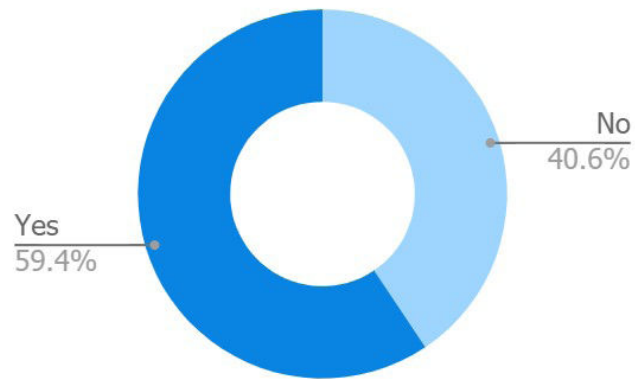
Out of those municipalities where reconstruction was going on during lockdown, 75% reported that 1-10 houses were undergoing reconstruction in their area. Similarly, 26% reported more than 10 houses with a maximum of 50 houses under construction in few areas.

Households that are continuing reconstruction/retrofitting of their houses

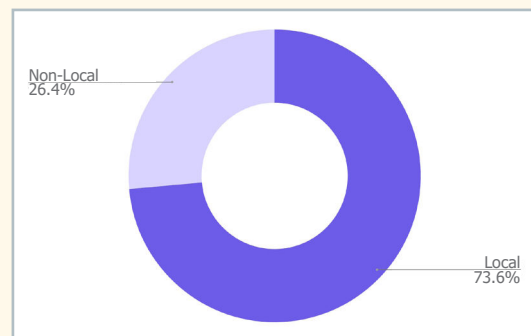
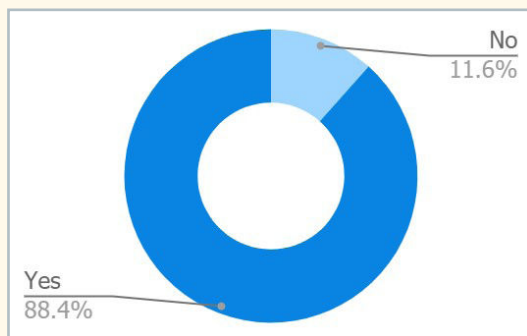




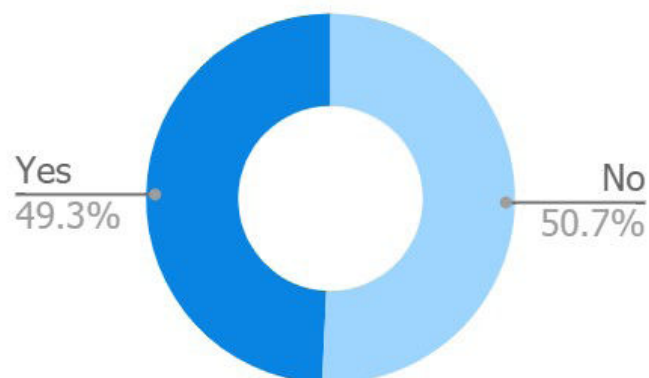
Construction materials were available in 60% of the municipalities even during lockdown.



While 88% municipalities reported having masons and labors available even during lockdown, 74% said local mason/labors were available and 26% said non-local masons and labors were also available along with locals.

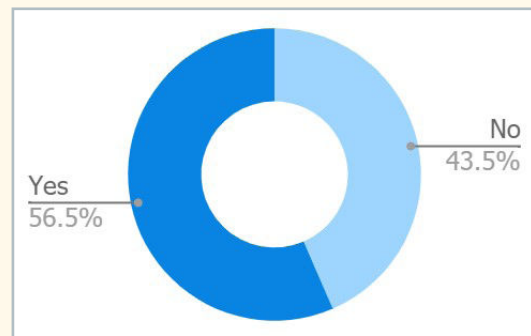
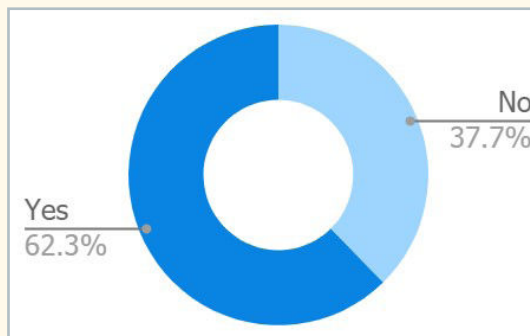


Almost 50% of the municipalities said some kind of transportation services were available in their areas.





62% municipalities were found to be supporting the households that were continuing reconstruction during the lockdown period. The support has been provided by municipalities staff and technical staff to those people undergoing reconstruction and for any information, issues/concerns related to reconstruction. 57% of municipalities reported that the beneficiaries in their area contacted them for reconstruction related information, issues and concerns.



The most sought information by people was on tranche update (82%) which shows most people have not received the tranches that they are eligible to receive. This is followed by Grievance Redressal (46%), Technical Support (41%), New Beneficiary list (28%) and others (15%) that included information on NRA reconstruction deadline, finding local labors and requesting for house inspection.



82
PERCENT
Tranche
Update



46
PERCENT
Grievance
Update



41
PERCENT
Technical
Support



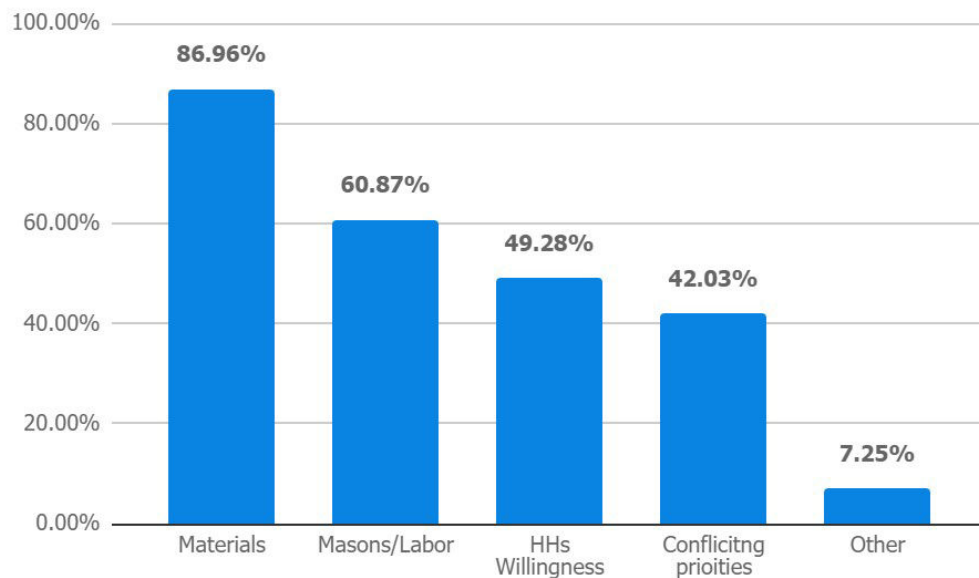
28
PERCENT
New Benef.
List



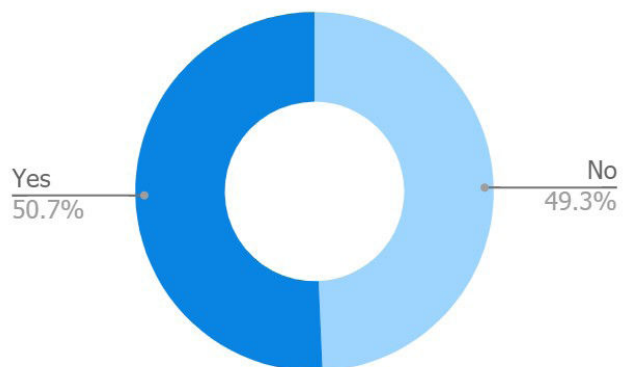
15
PERCENT
Others

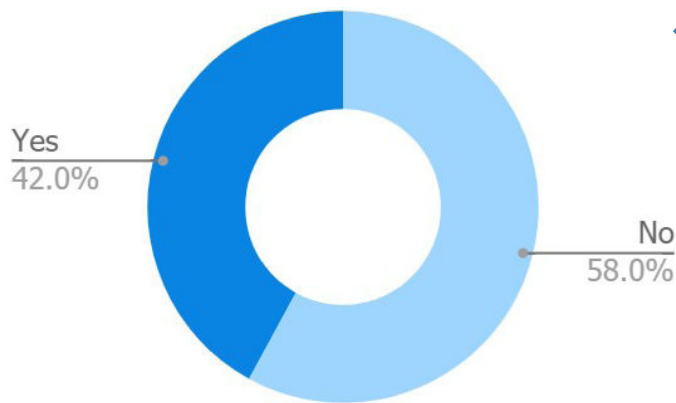


The most impact COVID-19 lockdown had on reconstruction was on the availability of construction materials as reported by 87% of the municipalities due the restriction in transportation movement. 61% reported on masons and labors as many have travelled to their hometown. Additionally, 49% of municipalities reported that the uncertainty of the lockdown period has affected the interest of the people in reconstruction during this time. Also, during this crisis time, the priorities have shifted towards COVID-19 response and other works related to contain the spread of the infection, thus affecting the reconstruction. Further, some other impacts reported were on inspection/monitoring of houses and people not getting technical support and delay in the tranche processing.



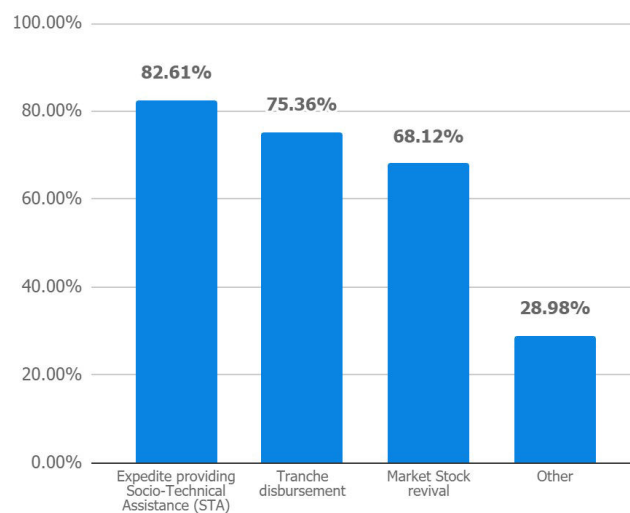
51% of the Municipalities believe the reconstruction can move in a normal way after the lockdown is lifted while 49% think it might not be normal due to other conflicting priorities.



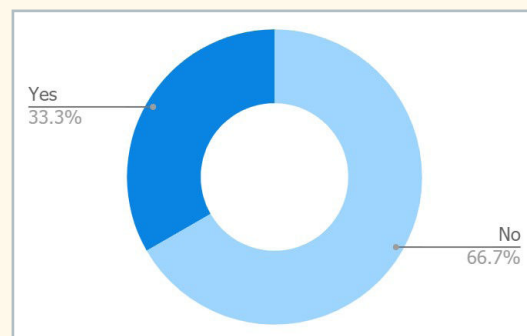
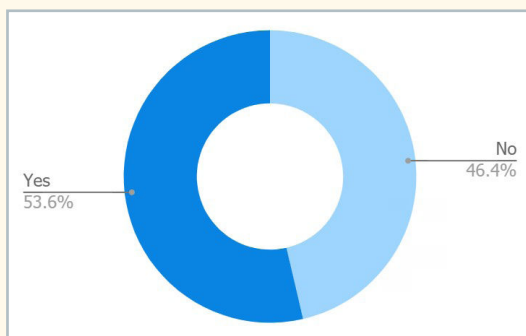


58% municipalities reported that they have plan to speed up reconstruction after the lockdown.

Providing socio-technical assistance to the beneficiaries after the lockdown is crucial to speed up reconstruction as suggested by 83% of Municipal Representatives. Others include timely tranche disbursement to the beneficiaries (75%) and revival of construction materials 68% to start reconstruction after the lockdown. Others included guideline and policy from NRA, extension of deadline, increase field monitoring, lobbying with wards.



54% of municipalities reported that reconstruction works could continue during the monsoon as well in their areas after the lockdown. Only 33% of municipalities have a Monsoon Preparedness plan such as Disaster Preparedness Plan, Monsoon Recovery Framework with a budget allocated for the response.

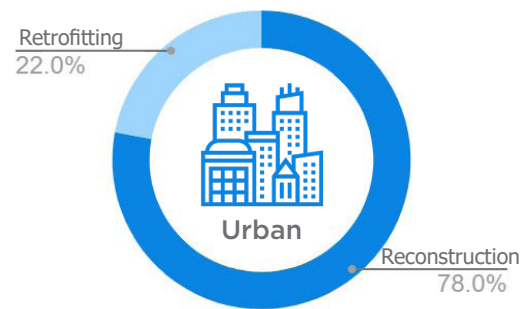
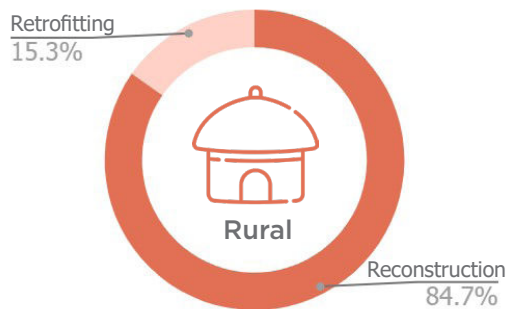




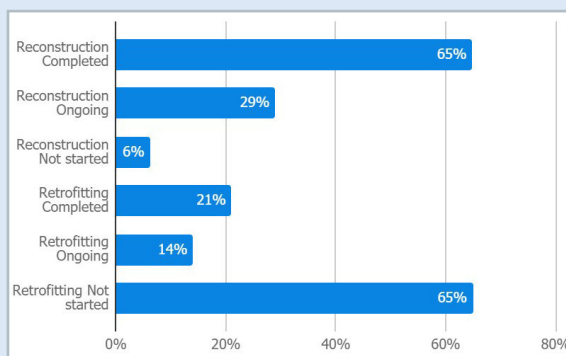
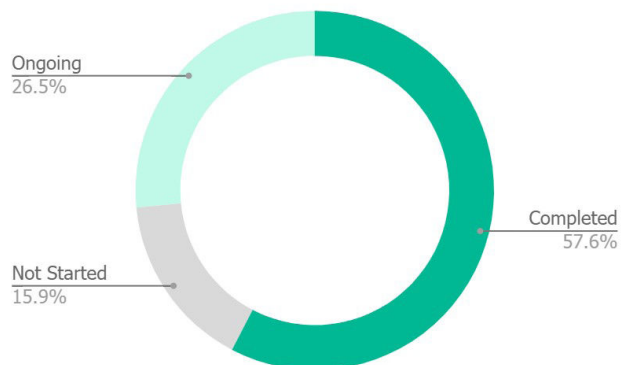
Key Findings

Beneficiaries

A total of 347 households enlisted in Government reconstruction and retrofitting grant schemes responded to the survey. Of which, 290 households were under reconstruction list and 57 households were under retrofitting list. Likewise, in Urban, total households combined for reconstruction and retrofitting were 59 and in Rural were 288 households.



Overall, in terms of house status^[1] 58% households were under “Completed”, 26% houses were under “Ongoing” and 16% of the households were under “Not started” categories with either reconstruction or retrofitting.



Overall, of the 16% households that have not started, 33% belong to reconstruction and 67% belong to retrofitting households. Out of the 290 reconstruction households, 6% had not started to build houses. Similarly, 65% out of the 57 retrofitting households had not started retrofitting.

^[1] Broadly, the reconstruction and retrofitting house status are categorized as Completed, Ongoing and Not Started.

Completed: Households that have completed reconstruction or retrofitting and no works remaining.

Ongoing: Households with reconstruction or retrofitting underway before the lockdown was imposed on 25 March 2020 but may or may not be continuing after the lockdown.

Not Started: Households under NRA list either taken first tranche or not, but have not started with reconstruction/retrofitting



Survey Comparison of House Status in Rural and Urban



Rural

244

RESPONDENTS

Total Reconstruction Households



Urban

46

RESPONDENTS

54%



Completed

11%

24%



Ongoing

5%

6%



Not started

44

RESPONDENTS

Total Retrofitting Households

13

RESPONDENTS

14%



Completed

7%

11%



Ongoing

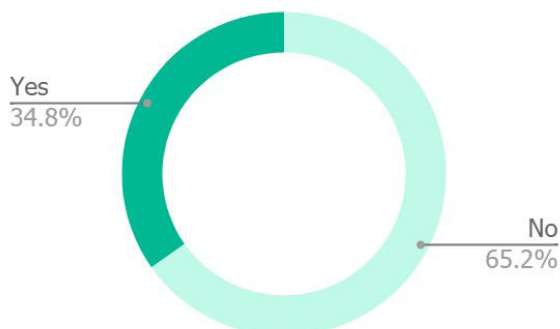
3%

53%

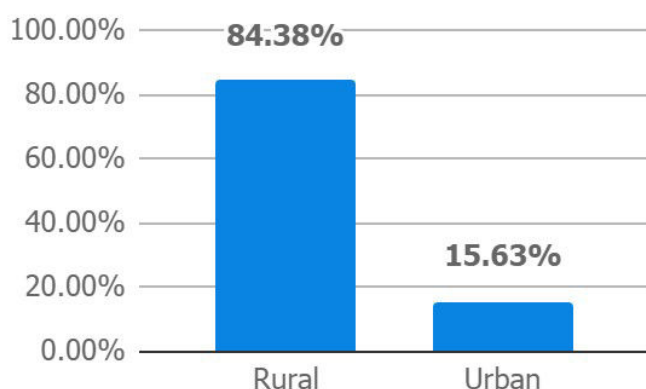


Not started

12%



Out of the 26% Ongoing reconstruction and retrofitting, 35% households reported continuing reconstruction or retrofitting during the lockdown period.



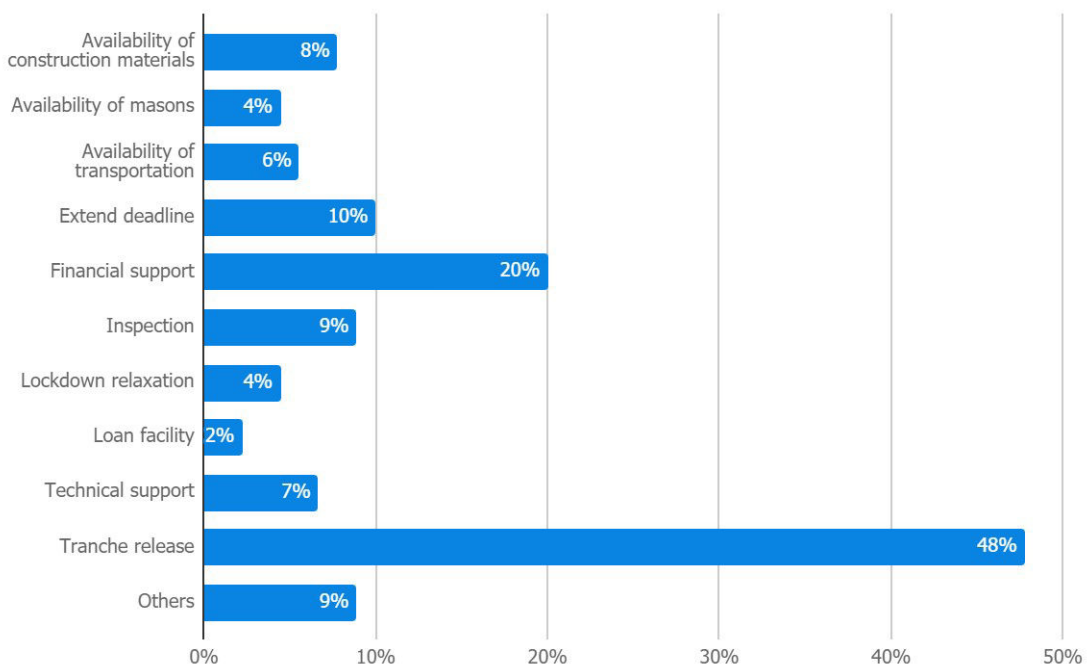
Out of the 35% continuing reconstruction work during lockdown, 84% households were in Rural and only 16% in Urban.

Availability of construction materials was reported to be the major challenge both in Rural and Urban even during pre-lockdown period as 45% of people in rural and 50% in Urban said they had challenges in getting construction materials. After the lockdown, the problem in getting construction materials has been more difficult, increasing by 30% each for Rural and Urban, where 78% people in Rural and 80% in Urban reported facing problems getting construction materials. The major challenge reported in Urban was the availability of masons and laborers where 80%, twice as more, to the pre-lockdown period. Further, another challenge reported in Urban was transportation (60%) and availability of water (40%) for reconstruction. While in Rural, financial challenges were already there before the lockdown.





The most required support by the people from the Government was the tranche release on time so they could continue their reconstruction work.

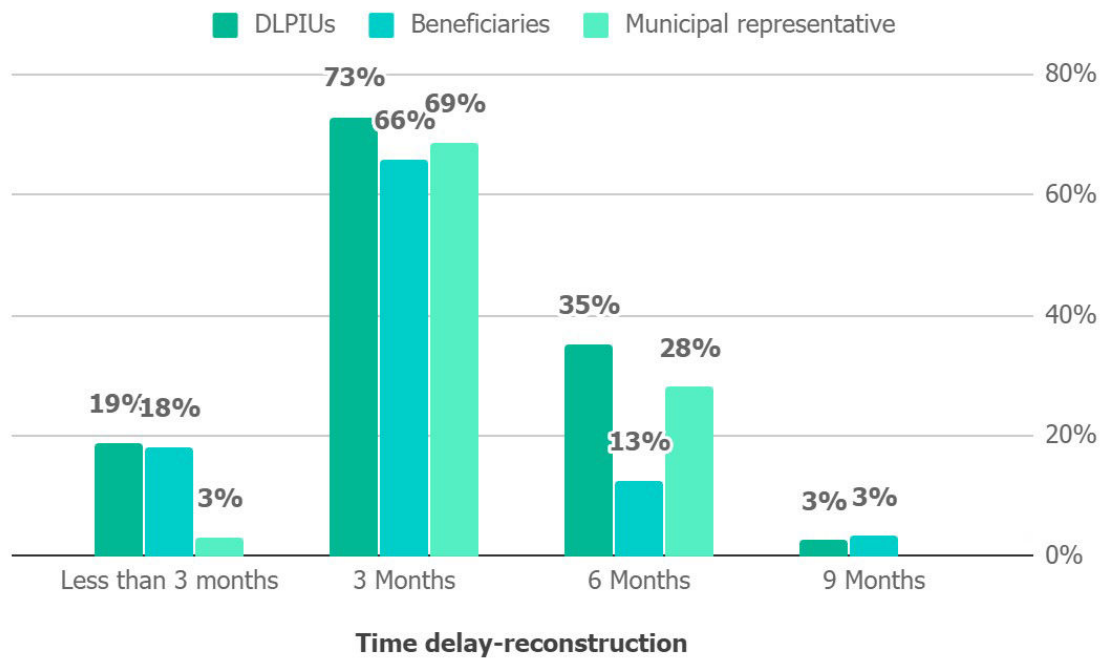




Key Findings

Expected Delay in reconstruction (Combined for DLPIU, Municipalities, Beneficiaries)

All stakeholders normally expected three months delay in the reconstruction process. Some stakeholders are still optimistic about the COVID19 causing less than 3 months of delay in the regular process while a small fraction believe that COVID19 will cause more than 9 months of delay.





Key Findings

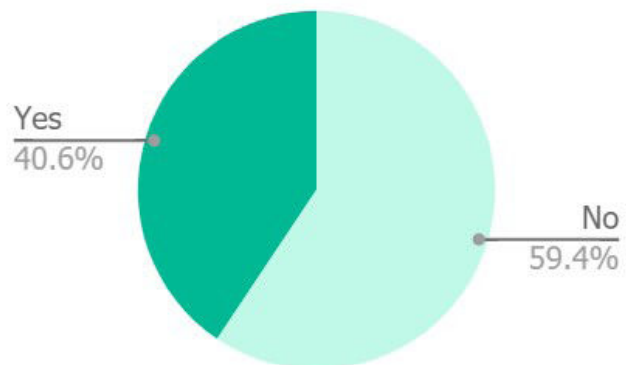
Social Mobilizers



Some Major Tasks of Social Mobilizers

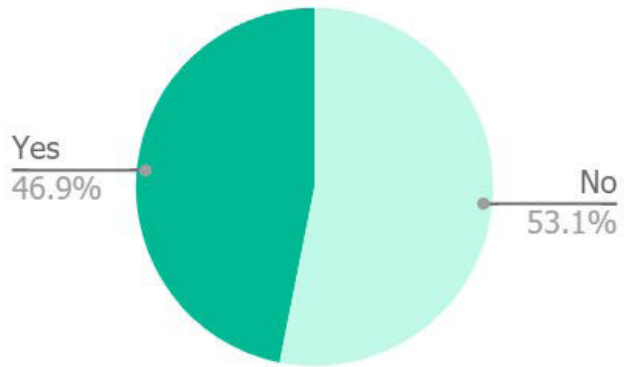
- Tracking the one-to-one reconstruction and retrofitting households especially focusing on those delaying reconstruction and retrofitting including the vulnerable households.
- Work in close coordination with mobile masons, focal engineers, Municipalities and District to facilitate in providing socio-technical assistance.
- Awareness and information dissemination to people on NRA guideline and policies in collaboration with local representatives.
- Support in identification of issues and concerns in reconstruction and retrofitting and facilitate with concerned stakeholders to address them.
- Support District and Municipalities Retrofit Task Force in data collection.
- Report progress to Municipal focal engineers and DLPIU.

41% Social Mobilizers reported working at their duty station during lockdown.





47% reported that they were supporting reconstruction, facilitating coordination between beneficiaries and mobile mason, visiting beneficiaries' houses near them, and creating awareness among beneficiaries on reconstruction amidst the COVID-19 lockdown.



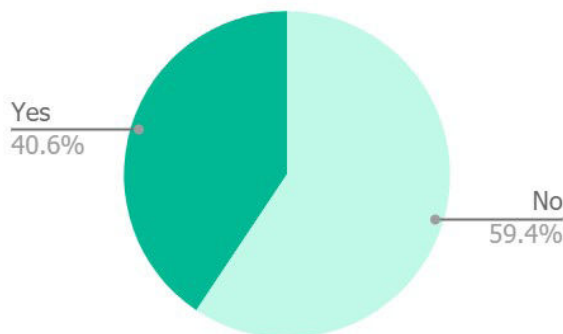
87% of Social Mobilizers reported that they were supporting the beneficiaries via phone for any concerns related to reconstruction. While 73% were also supporting the site itself.



87
PERCENT

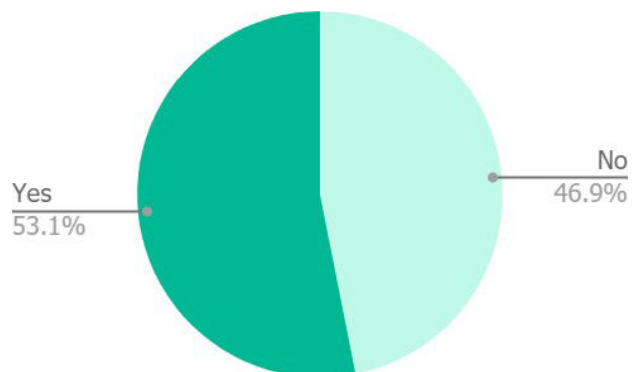


73
PERCENT



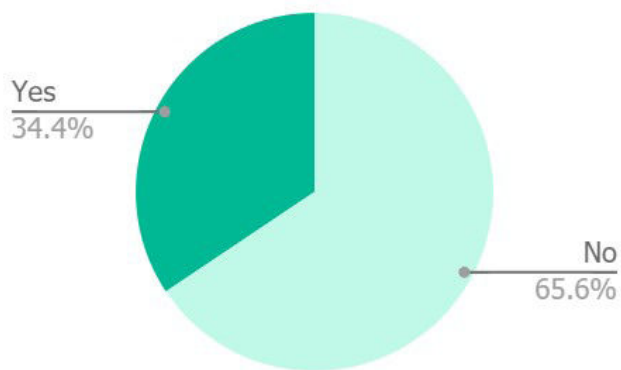
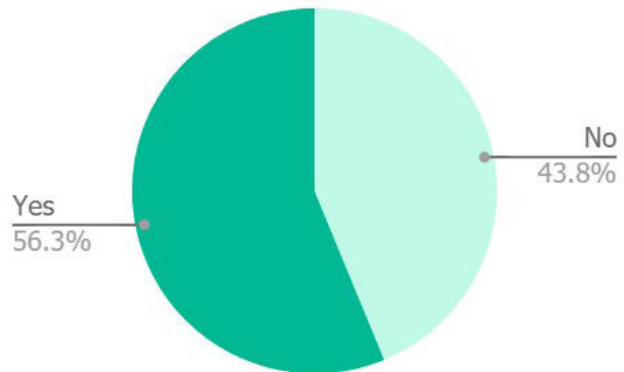
41% of Social Mobilizers said beneficiaries in their area reached out to them seeking support and most of them were asking for information on tranche updates, grievance updates.

53% Social Mobilizers said they have been collecting information on households that have not started reconstruction before the lockdown. As directed by the municipalities and Engineers, Social Mobilizers have been collecting information on households who have not started reconstruction retrofitting to identify the reasons for not starting, to inform and encourage them to start providing and facilitating the support required and eventually to complete the reconstruction process.



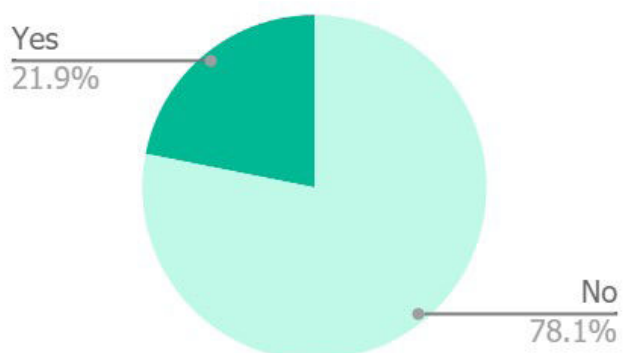


56% of Social Mobilizers reported that they have been supporting the reconstruction of vulnerable households in their working areas.



66% of Social Mobilizers said they have a monthly target of supporting households for expediting the reconstruction, retrofitting including the reconstruction of vulnerable households.

Only 22 % of Social Mobilizers said they have some sort of action plan to support and facilitate the reconstruction of households.





Key Findings

Masons



Some Major Tasks of Mobile Masons

- Conduct Door to Door visits of houses to identify the needs and gaps in socio-technical assistance and compile the households that need assistance for reconstruction.
- Provide technical support to masons who are engaged in reconstruction or retrofitting of houses.
- Conduct awareness on NRA guidelines, policies to the people in close coordination with local representatives.
- Identity issues and concerns related to reconstruction and retrofitting and coordinate with concerned authorities to address them.
- Support District and Municipal Retrofit Task Force in data collection.

Majority of masons present were from Rural areas, 71% with only 29 % from Urban areas.



71

PERCENT



29

PERCENT

45% of Masons locally recruited were working in their duty station during lockdown.





Out of 45% of masons working at the duty station, 95% were physically present at work and were constructing houses, 5% also provided support through the phone.

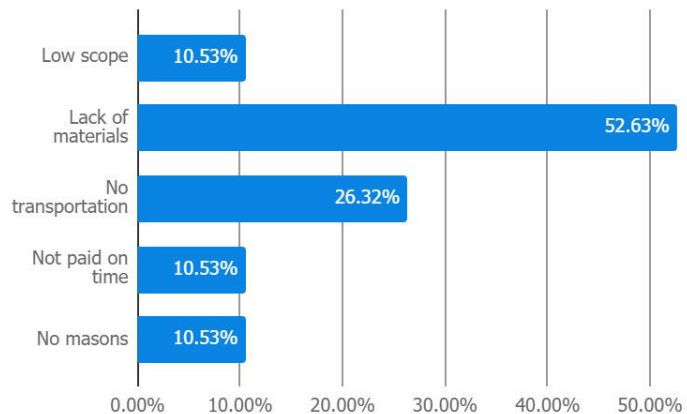


5
PERCENT



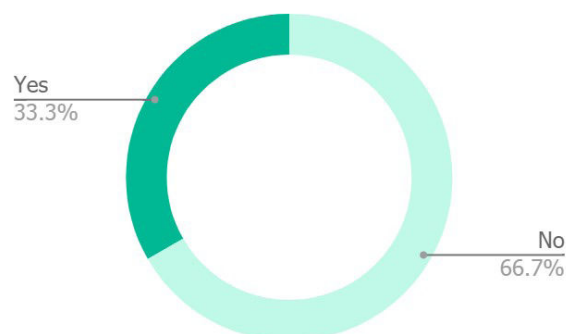
95
PERCENT

The major challenge faced by masons was lack of construction materials (53%) attributed to transportation restriction due to lockdown. They also reported to be working with limited resources (materials, labors) as many masons went to their hometown. Masons also remarked on being not paid on time (10%) and also less scope as beneficiaries were showing less interest in reconstruction.



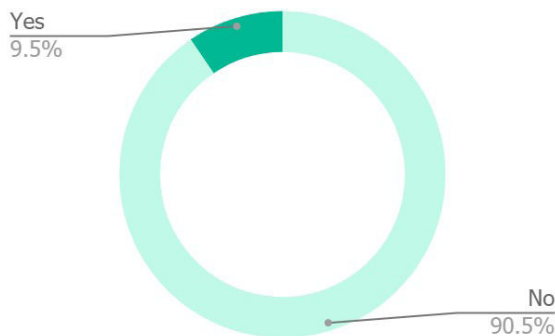
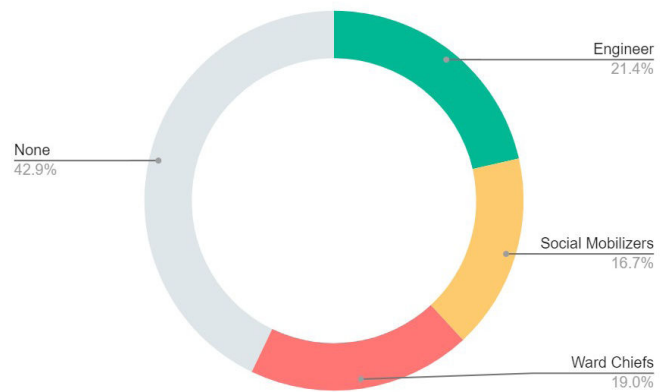
57% Masons said they were getting support from Technical staff and Social Mobilizers.

Only 33% masons reported supporting the construction of Vulnerable Households.

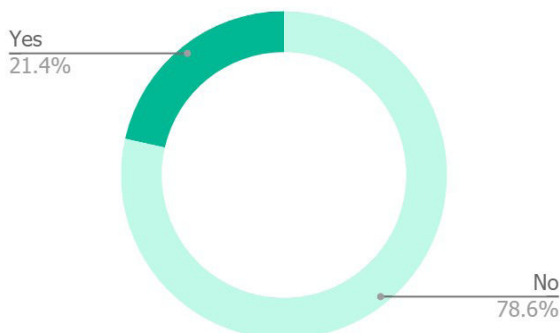




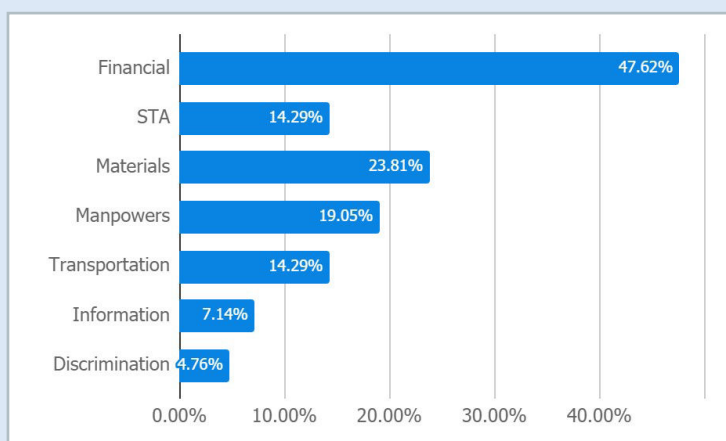
Of those masons supporting the reconstruction of vulnerable households are getting support from Engineers (21%), Ward Chiefs (19%) and Social Mobilizers (17%). 43% were not getting any support to identify the vulnerable households.



Only 10% masons reported having a target for Vulnerable Households reconstruction.



21% masons said they were reporting on a monthly progress of vulnerable house construction and constraints to their supervisor.



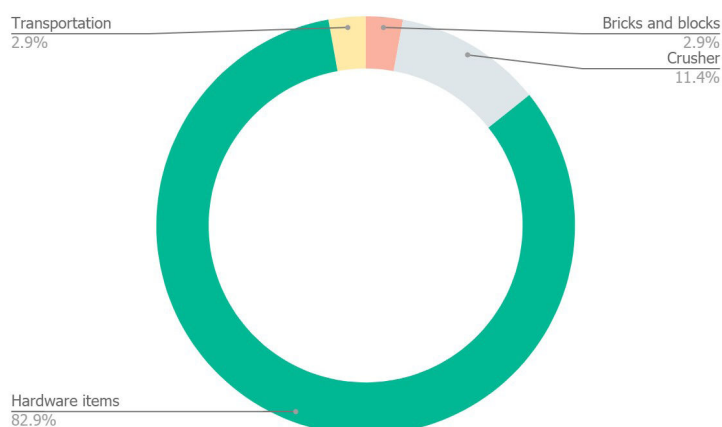
As reported by masons, due to poor economic status and financial challenges as well as lack of proper socio-technical assistance, vulnerable households have difficulty choosing the reasonable housing typologies.

Key Findings

Vendors and Producers

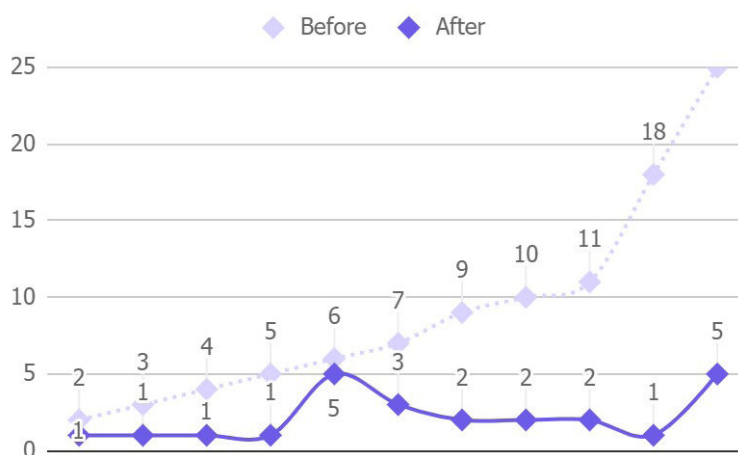
Vendors and Producers included those involved in business related to supplying construction materials such as hardware shops, those providing transportation services and dealers of bricks, cement, gravel required for reconstruction at the district level.

Types of Materials supplied by the Vendors and Providers at the District.



67% had their businesses opened even during the lockdown period.

Changes in staff number to support business before and after lockdown.

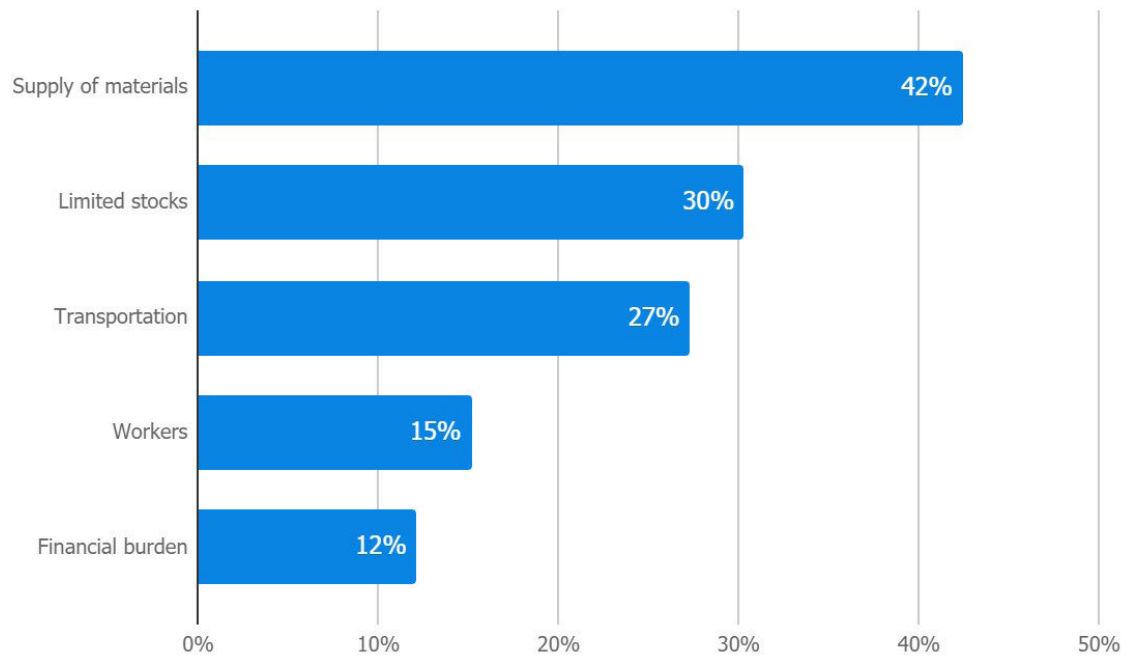




Demands for construction materials, 60% Vendors reported that there was demand for construction materials even during lockdown in their areas.



Challenges and constraints in business operation faced by vendors and providers due to COVID-19 lockdown.





Other Challenges and Impact of COVID-19

The following are some of the anecdotal observations shared by the recovery and reconstruction stakeholders during the assessment as well as multiple sharing sessions with organized by HRRP to discuss the impact of COVID19 and the way forward.

- After COVID-19 crisis, people have realized the value of houses in villages. Hopefully, after the lockdown, households who have not started reconstruction after taking the first tranche will start reconstruction of their houses.
- The major impact has been on livelihood, health and education of families and children of beneficiaries.
- COVID-19 halted the reconstruction process at the time of peak building season, now with the start of the monsoon that will remain more or less the same until August-September 2020, the reconstruction process will be delayed beyond the physical lockdown.
- Economic and social impact of COVID-19 can be foreseen delaying reconstruction work as priorities of people might change to move towards strengthening their economy rather than expanding their living space or repair works or new construction.
- People are finding it difficult to reengage in reconstruction due to the fear of COVID-19 transmission.
- Migrant workers makeup a major workforce, with most migrant workers back to their hometown during lockdown, their return will be very crucial to have the reconstruction in full swing. Additionally, it is important to ensure health safety and security for all to facilitate their return to work.
- The lockdown has changed the priority of the local Government in response to the COVID-19 crisis, community and local government are distributing relief packages for the most vulnerable those who are hard hit by lockdown.
- The use of banking systems for tranche transfers has a great success in Nepal's recovery and reconstruction. This sector has also been impacted as people still need to travel great distances and sometimes compromise the physical-distance norms to withdraw their tranches from bank accounts.
- The psychological effect on people due to pandemic cannot be neglected. The uncertainty of opening the markets for material supply, manpower is affecting the beneficiaries' plan to complete private housing reconstruction on time.



Recommendations and the way forward

The following recommendations and way forward are drawn from the assessment responses as well as [the webinar organized by NRA and HRRP](#) focused on IMPACT of COVID-19 on Post-Earthquake Recovery and Reconstruction in Nepal and the way forward.

- NRA should organize a Joint reconstruction strategy and planning event with inputs from development partners to complete remaining reconstruction work in remaining time frame with clear exit strategy. Such strategy and planning should have a flexible timeline considering the lockdown related inactivity.
- NRA to coordinate with relevant government agencies and private sector to make sure that the essential construction materials and supplies are available.
- NRA to develop and publish safety and security during recovery and reconstruction guidelines to resume the recovery and reconstruction activities at the field-level. Development partners can contribute their technical expertise to ensure that all concerns are appropriately addressed.
- All stakeholders ensure proper communication and dissemination safety and security during recovery and reconstruction guidelines, norms of social distancing and hygiene and provide training and orientations to the field staff and community members. Use of IEC materials, mass media (TV and radio) and social media could be the appropriate means.
- Increase collaboration among Government, Partner Organizations and all other concerned reconstruction stakeholders to ensure that reconstruction activities comply with safety considerations as per NRA guideline.
- Continue monitoring to ensure field staff and communities are undertaking the necessary precautions and following the safety protocols at the construction sites and government offices.
- Increase focus on recovery of livelihood and economy through continuity of reconstruction process and strategy to integrate COVID recovery with the remaining reconstruction efforts.
- Develop flexible and fast-track plans to support remaining, those who want to reconstruct or retrofit and vulnerable caseloads. The following recommendations are likely to complement.
 1. Maximize the use of human resources available with NRA at the field level possibly by assigning temporary roles in their current location.
 2. Fast-track tranche disbursement and continue inspection possibly remotely or by following the norms of physical distancing.
 3. Effective mobilization of field staff to provide targeted Socio-Technical



Assistance (STA) support to those who have not completed the reconstruction process

4. Partners should extend STA support through local staff (mobile masons and Social Mobilizers) and organize more remote support sessions.
 5. Refresher trainings for field technical staff will be very important as they will be coming back to their duty stations after a pro-longed inactivity and could be oriented on how to resume and set priorities complementing the NRA strategy.
 6. Finalize the guidelines and SOP for vulnerable support and distribute the fifty thousand top-ups to vulnerable households and ensure no one is left behind.
 7. Fast-track the grievance redressal mechanism.
- All stakeholders need to advocate for the waiver or subsidy on interest incurred on housing reconstruction loans. This is more important with deteriorating livelihood options with COVID19.
 - Donors/Partners to realign their program and funding priority in reconstruction along with flexible funding for COVID response.
 - HRRP should also streamline their activities at ward and municipal level in order to build capacity of the staff and for long term sustainability and transition the current investments into longer-term recovery.
 - Increase coordination between stakeholders at the local level. This will also require initiatives to increase active participation of local municipal representatives, technical staffs and community-leaders.

In collaboration with:



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